Thanksgiving 2026 Planner Checklist, Nov. 26

A dated plan from the guest list to the last of the leftovers

WEEKS BEFORE

- [ ] Set a guest count and ask about allergies and diets — Week of Oct. 26
- [ ] Plan the menu and reserve a fresh turkey if you want one — Mon., Nov. 2
- [ ] Buy a frozen turkey at about one pound per guest — Nov. 14 to 18

THANKSGIVING WEEK

- [ ] Start fridge-thawing a 20 to 24 lb turkey — By Fri., Nov. 20
- [ ] Start fridge-thawing a 16 to 20 lb turkey — By Sat., Nov. 21
- [ ] Start fridge-thawing a 12 to 16 lb turkey — By Sun., Nov. 22
- [ ] Start fridge-thawing a 4 to 12 lb turkey — By Mon., Nov. 23
- [ ] Buy a fresh turkey, one to two days before cooking — Nov. 24 or 25
- [ ] Prep sides; chill wet stuffing ingredients separately — Wed., Nov. 25

THURSDAY

- [ ] Heat the oven to at least 325°F, never lower — Thu., Nov. 26
- [ ] Cook turkey and stuffing to 165°F; check thigh, wing and breast — Thu., Nov. 26
- [ ] Rest the turkey 20 minutes before carving — Thu., Nov. 26
- [ ] Refrigerate leftovers within 2 hours in shallow containers — Thu., Nov. 26

LEFTOVERS

- [ ] Use refrigerated leftovers within 3 to 4 days — By Sun., Nov. 29
- [ ] Freeze what is left for best quality in 2 to 6 months — Mon., Nov. 30

Guest count, menu notes, who brings what

Source: USDA Food Safety and Inspection Service, Let's Talk Turkey; U.S. Fire Administration. Planning dates are our suggestion; safety steps and times are the USDA's.